2020.[23] As states began to demand larger quantities, the GoI had to think of options to not only augment the supply but also make arrangements for its transport. In April 2020 itself, the DCGI had issued orders to industrial gas manufacturers to be allowed to be given licences for manufacturing medical oxygen within 24 hours of application. Looking at the rising requirements of medical oxygen, the MoHFW issued an order with immediate effect to use LMO for medical purposes only. As a result of these interventions, the supply of medical oxygen increased from 1,250 MT to 8,914 MT in less than four weeks. Steel plants enhanced their daily production by reducing production of liquid nitrogen and liquid argon, cutting down usage of gaseous oxygen and decreasing safety stock from 3.5 days to 0.5 days, thus making available about 25,000 MT of LMO in their storage tanks. This resulted in increased LMO from them to 3,250 MT per day by 1 April and subsequently 4,000 MT per day by 10 May from their pre-COVID levels.

During the meeting, the prime minister was apprised of all the aforementioned actions, but he felt that more efforts would need to be made to augment production and subsequently supply. Focus was on the 12 high burden states of Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, UP, Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan, where officials presented district-level data on the COVID-19 situation. The prime minister was also briefed on the mechanism which the states and the Centre was adopting while working together on projecting and estimating oxygen demand for the next fortnight—under which 4,880 MT of oxygen would go out to these states by 20 April, 5,619 MT by 25 April and 6,593 MT by 30 April. The prime minister directed the officials to make attempts to increase production capacities of the oxygen production plants. To ensure that there would be no issues in movement of tankers carrying oxygen, the prime minister advised that all necessary action including exemption from registration permits for interstate tankers and procedural road blocks must be cleared. If demand for oxygen increased drastically and the supply was matched, the prime minister pre-empted the need for additional tankers and cylinders which would be required concurrently. India currently had about 1,200 cryogenic tankers in circulation and if LMO demand went up so would the need for transporting equipment. Hence, based on the advice of the experts, the team made a decision to allow using nitrogen and argon tankers to transport oxygen which would take the number up to 2,000 and also permitted the use of